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often out of stock, given its limited quantity. It can be pre-booked.

Japanese tea is in high demand at tea auctions. In November, less than a kg of green tea leaves from Japan sold for a record-breaking 1.96 million yen—or about \$15,500 (₹12.82 lakh). This surpassed the previous record of 1.08 million yen or \$8,500 (₹7 lakh) set in 2021. The record-breaking tea leaves were grown in Fujinomiya, a city in Shizuoka prefecture, known for its high-quality green teas.

In India, one of the most expensive teas is the Silver Tips Imperial Tea. Grown at the Makaibari Tea Estate in Darjeeling, the tea comes from special buds that look like silver needles. The tea leaves are plucked only on full moon nights because of the belief that the planetary alignment on full moon nights helps optimise the flavour of the tea. As a result, it can be plucked only three to four times during the harvest season, making production limited. The semi-fermented oolong tea has a fruity aroma and was sold

1. The Makaibari Tea Estate in Darjeeling is home to Silver Tips Imperial Tea, considered one of the most expensive in India

2. Singapore-based TWG Tea sells exclusive teas such as Yellow Gold Tea Buds and Imperial Gykuro

3. Global tea consumption is dominated by China (38 per cent) and India (19 per cent)

for \$1,850 (₹1.53 lakh) per kg in 2014 at an auction. Currently it is available for \$36 (₹3,000) for 50 gm, or \$720 (₹60,000) for a kg on the Makaibari website. The tea estate says that the tea is anti-ageing and relaxing, and is best sipped at bedtime.

In December last year, 1 kg of tea from Assam sold at an auction for ₹1,51,000. Called Golden Pearl from the Nahorchukbari estate in Assam's Dibrugarh area, the tea was bought by a Russian tea company.

The global tea industry is estimated to be worth \$21.3 billion by 2024, according to United Nations projections. Not surprisingly, global tea consumption is dominated by China (38 per cent) and India (19 per cent). According to the UN, the tea sector proved resilient against economic recessions triggered by Covid-19. Expectedly. After all, it's always teatime, as the Mad Hatter remarked to Alice in *Alice in Wonderland*. **BT**

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